

Editorial

Dear Readers,

The buzzwords in 2009 seem to be 'recession', 'downturn', 'cost-cuts', and 'layoffs'. Naturally, the pressure on the tech community has also increased exponentially. Every discussion seems to start and end with "constraints on budgets". Customers (and our bosses) not only expect quality solutions to be delivered on time, but at lower costs too.

Can Open Source be our messiah during these challenging times?

Shane Owenby, director, Linux & Open Source, Asia Pacific, Oracle Corporation (interviewed on Page 64) surely thinks so. Many articles in leading business magazines, like *Fortune*, *eWeek*, etc. seem to suggest the same. Closer to home, many IT heads are suggesting that they are more interested today to understand the long-term financial and technical implications of Open Source solutions. But, they also outline a few challenges—many of which we have discussed earlier.

The most popular one continues to be "lack of support", or what is now being touted as "a visible lack of support". Just with the addition of a single word, "visible", the nature of the challenge that the open source community needs to overcome changes tremendously. What the decision-makers seem to be saying is that, despite the claims of adequate support for open source, they don't see much evidence of the same. If the proprietary world is looked upon as being monopolistic, there don't seem to be many choices in the open source world either. Hence, they prefer "a known devil to an unknown one".

The second issue that seems to bother most IT heads is that for every challenge there are just too many options in the open source arena! As one CIO comments, "For content management systems, we have Joomla, Drupal, Wordpress, and fifteen more options! How do I evaluate them all, and decide which one is suited for me?" But, aren't there hundreds of options in the proprietary world too? "Yes, there are, but the leading brands are well-known, and the eco-system has multiple points of references for IT guys to make an informed choice."

But aren't these two challenges in contradiction to each other—the first states that there's limitation of choice in the open source world, while the other claims that the abundance of options makes life confusing?

Not really! The main concern with open source remains that while there are multiple solutions for any IT challenge, the number of vendors who can support these solutions are "visibly" limited or absent.

So, what can we do? First, the vendors need to be more visible and get more aggressive. If they keep waiting for their organisation to grow into a multi-million dollar business before they start marketing or projecting themselves as a brand, they may be losing an opportunity to grow. Second, we need to create more platforms where competing solutions can be presented together and reviewed by decision-makers.

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LFY's FOSS Yellow Pages is an attempt to help young Indian organisations in the open source arena announce their services to decision-makers in the IT world, and Open Source India (www.osidays.com) in March this year shall attempt to create yet another platform for competing solutions to meet. But, if we want to accelerate the adoption of open source in India, we will need to come together and create many such platforms. Can we do that?

"Yes, we can!"

Best Wishes!



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